and TRS and TDP ‘gave us no space to expand’. The TDP emerged first as the political articulation of Telugu pride, and TRS later, to create a separate Telangana. In Karnataka, on the other hand, no local sons-of-the-soil party emerged to take on the Congress. When Janata Dal/JD(S) were the primary anti-Congress force in the state in the 1990s, neither focused its politics on becoming a vehicle of Kannadiga pride. This was a crucial difference.

Besides, Vajpayee also needed the TDP’s support for his national coalition in Delhi, so the BJP could not afford to be aggressive in Andhra. Like Karnataka (with Lingayats, Vokkaligas and Kurubas), Andhra Pradesh has two major caste groups: Reddys and Kammas. Most chief ministers there have been Reddys or Kammas. Reddys have tended to be supportive of the Congress, while the Kammas moved to the TDP with the coming of N.T. Rama Rao in 1983. As a senior Karnataka BJP political strategist explained to me, ‘Till NTR, Kammas had largely voted for Congress. That changed in 1986 when N.T. Rama Rao, who was a Kamma, came in. So, they also have two dominant castes, like in Karnataka, and one which is a balancing caste: Kapus which was around 8–10 per cent. So, it was like balancing a scale … You had a similar situation here in Karnataka with Vokkaligas and Lingayats. There is a community called Kuruba, which are like Kapus, basically they are OBCs. They play the balancing act. In Karnataka, it was to Yediyurappa’s credit that BJP could exploit the Lingayat resentment after the Veerendra Patil incident. He understood the importance of it and grew our base among the Lingayat and SCs. We didn’t have equivalent leadership in Andhra Pradesh.’[110]

There were opportunities in both states, but what the BJP lacked in Andhra was ‘a leader who was ambitious like Amit Shah’, said Anand. ‘People forget that Yediyurappa formed the first BJP government in south India in 2008 when Narendra Modi had just started his second term as chief minister in Gujarat. If we had a leader like that in Andhra Pradesh or Tamil Nadu or Kerala, we would be in a different place today. Yediyurappa had the face of Vajpayee and was a street fighter like Amit Shah. This combination helped the party to grow in a big way. This is something that made a big difference.’ In other words, the difference lay in the creation of